KOEL

FOR PIANO QUINTET AND SAMPLER

Notes by Composer

Koel was written about the issues regarding water conservation and usage in India, though many of the core ideas apply to most modern metropolitan areas. Through the use of the sampler, audio excerpts of documentaries and interviews map many issues into melodic fragments, which are developed throughout the piece. The recordings used are as follows:

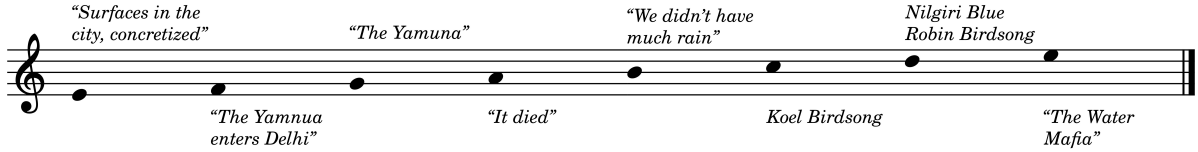
1. "We didn't have much rain", an excerpt taken from an interview in a DW Documentary on water scarcity in Banglore.
3. Excerpts of Koel birdsong, from the Xeno-Canto database (XC190873, by Pronoy Baidya)
4. Excerpts of the Nilgiri Blue Robin birdsong, from the Xeno-Canto database (XC825803, by Vincent van der Spek)
2. "The water mafia", an excerpt from a National Geographic interview of journalist Aman Sethi, referring to the private groups that
5. "The Yamuna enters Delhi...it died", an excerpt taken from a talk by water conservationist Jyoti Sharma, on the water crisis in Delhi. This excerpt is used 3 different ways. As "The Yamuna", "The Yamuna enters Delhi", and "it died".
6. "Surfaces in the city...concretized", an excerpt taken from a TRT World interview of Stalin Dayanand, an environmentalist serving as director of Vanashakti, a forest, wetland, and mangrove conservation focused NGO.

The piece traces how droughts and bad city planning enable the privatized water mafia to control water supply in cities, as rivers are polluted or dry up. The concretization of these cities prevents the monsoons and rains from replenishing the ground water at the same rate as it is being extracted, as rivers become unreliable sources of water.
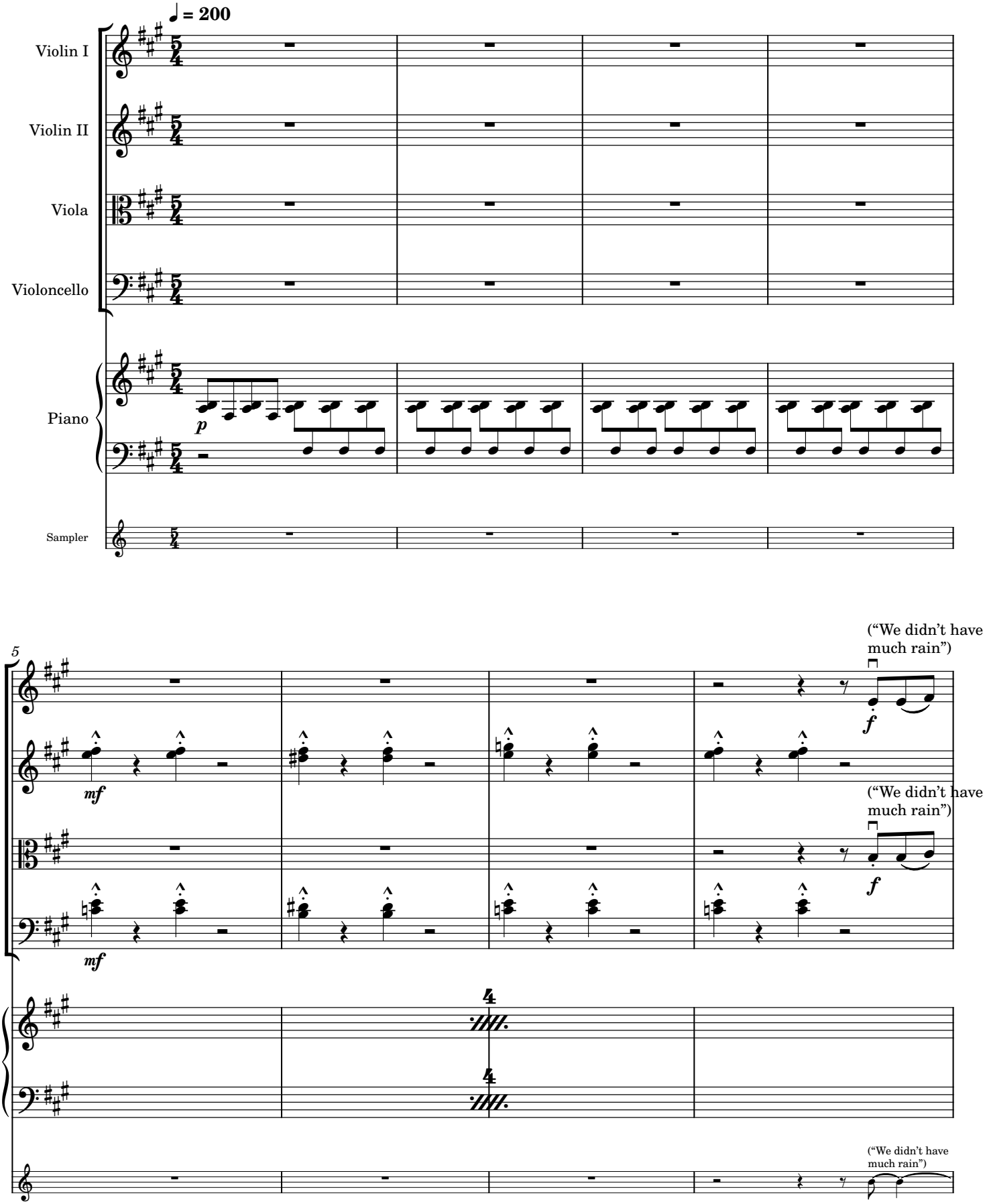
The title comes from the bird of the same name, which in India signals the arrival of spring and thus the monsoon season.

Performance Notes

Koel uses a sampler keyboard to enable the performance of excerpts from interviews and documentaries. The mapping used in the score is provided in the key below. In all cases, the speech melody is directly imitated by an instrument, and these melodies are identified through staff text on the sampler and instrument parts.



In the event a sampler is unavailable, these samples may be played through tape, or triggered manually by a performer through software such as Abelton Live.
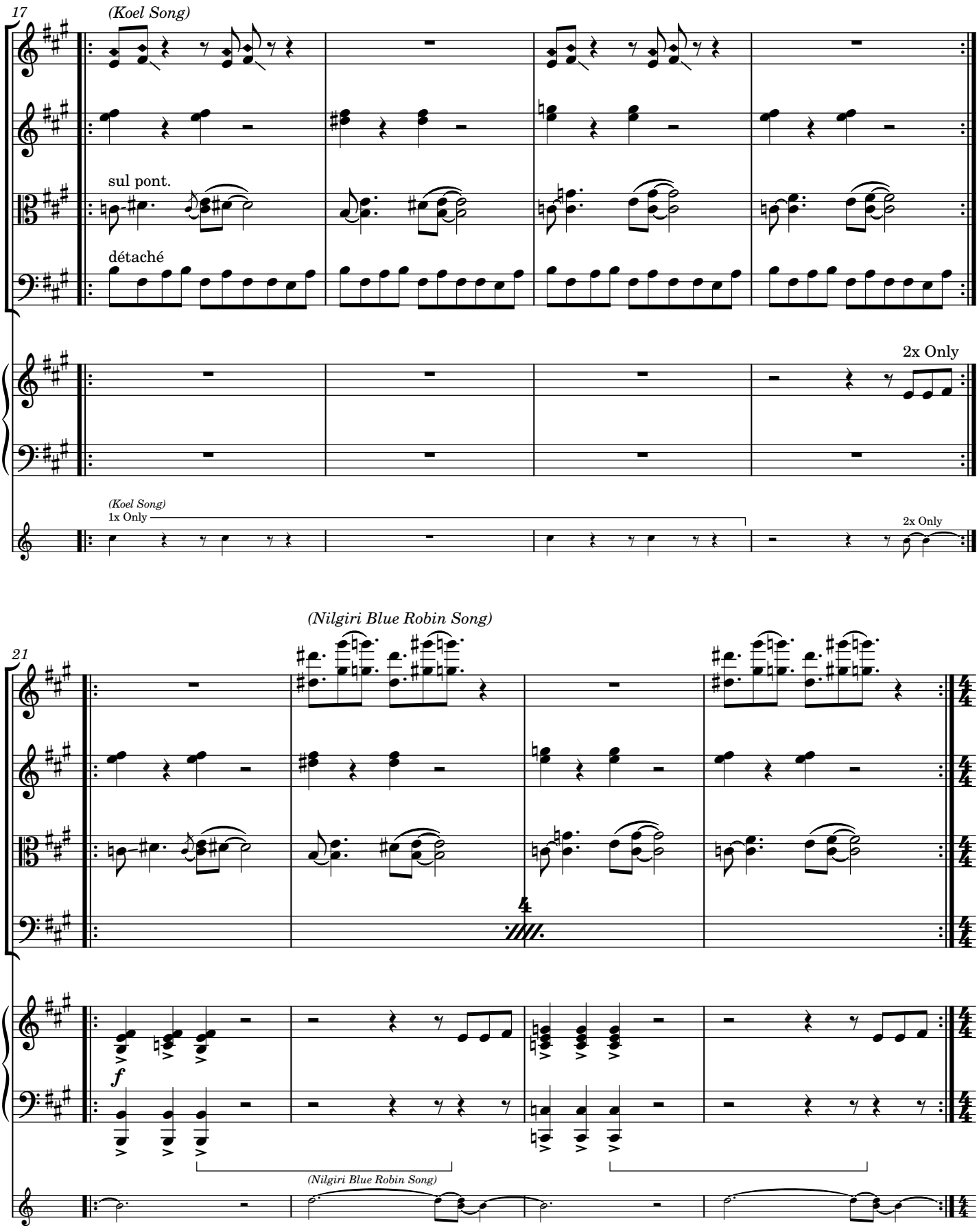

♩ = 200
Violin I
Violin II
Viola
Violoncello
Piano
Sampler
p
5
mf
mf
(“We didn’t have much rain”)
f
(“We didn’t have much rain”)
f
4
4
(“We didn’t have much rain”)
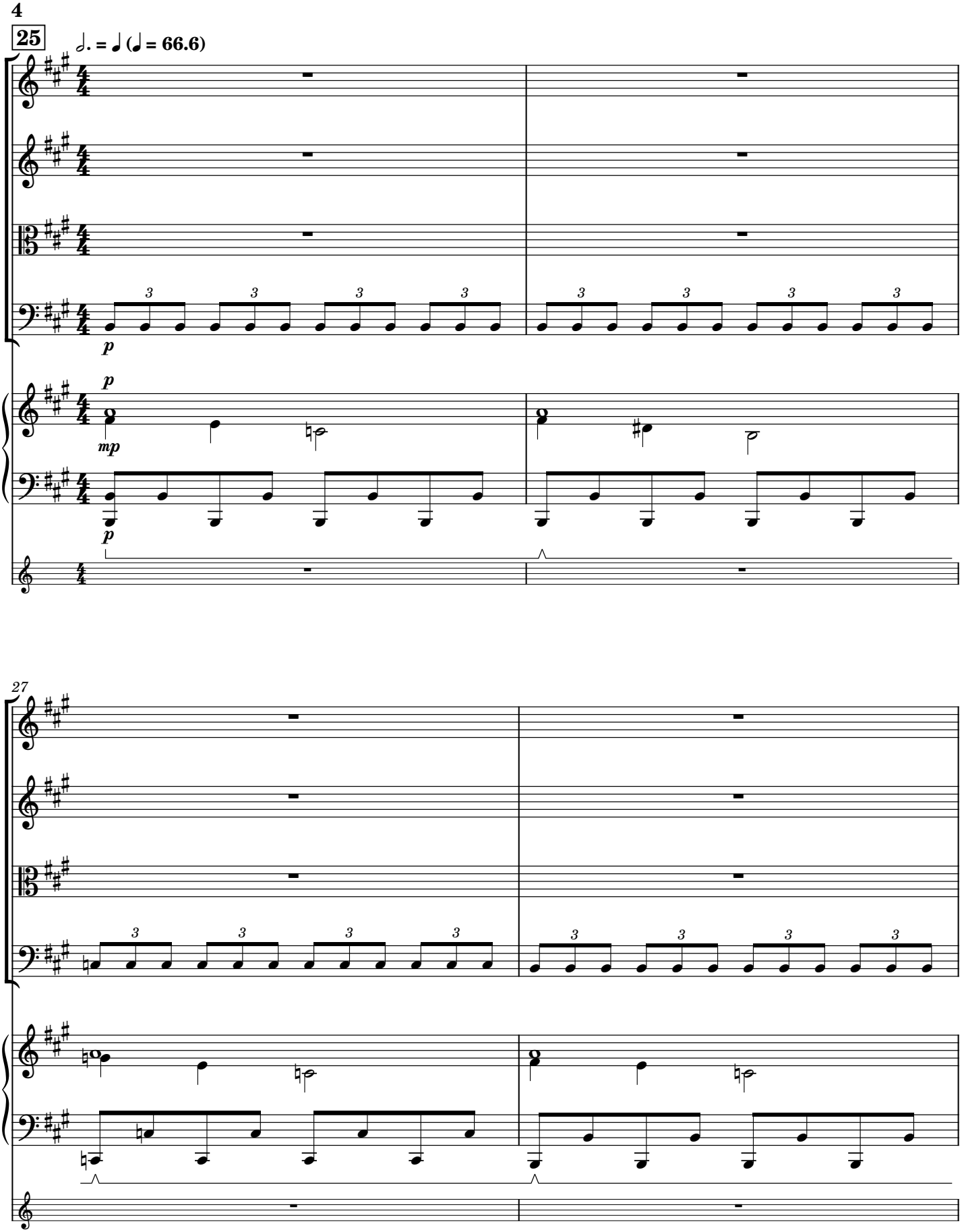
9
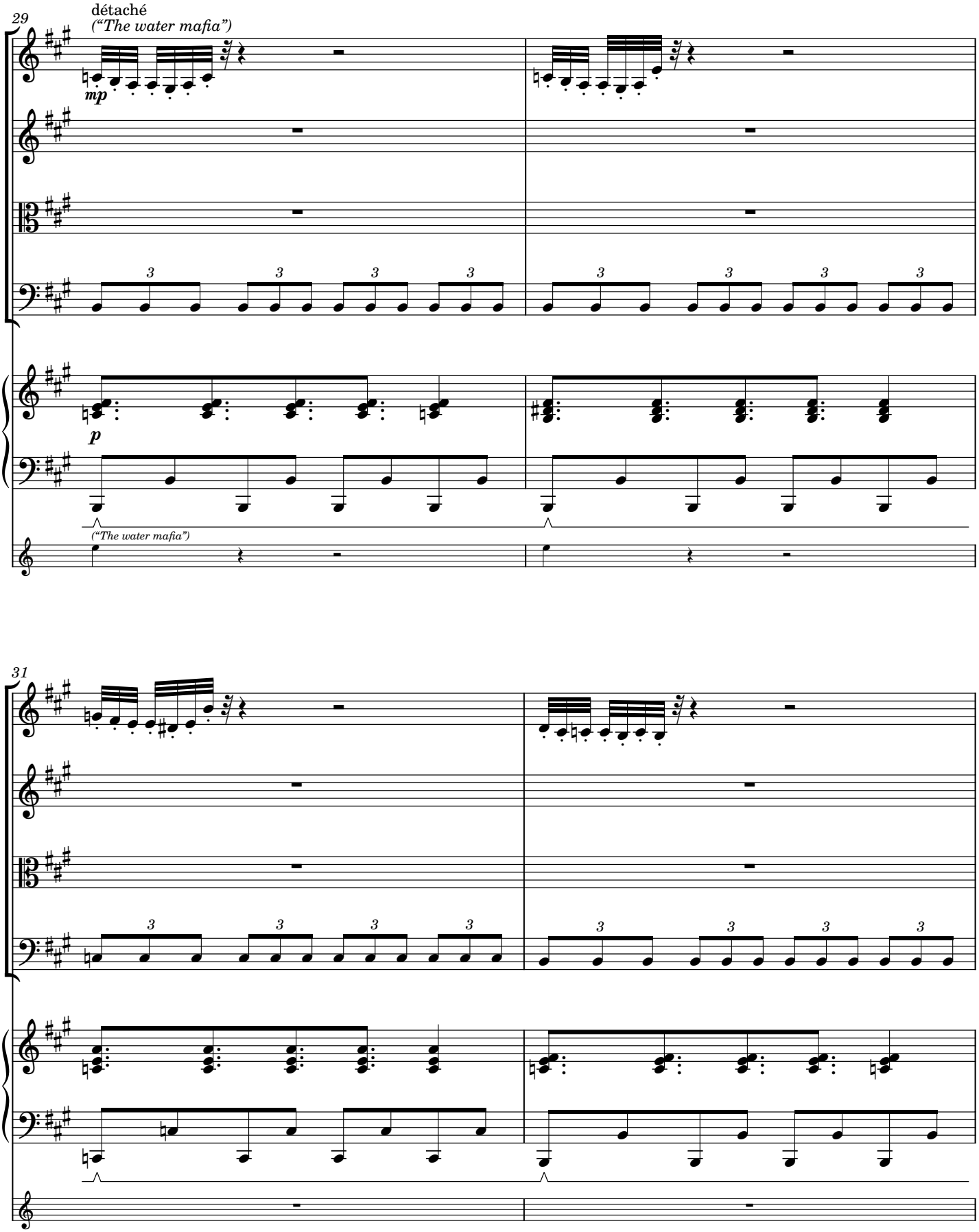
13

mp

molto espressivo


17
(Koel Song)
sul pont.
détaché
2x Only
(Koel Song)
1x Only
2x Only
(Nilgiri Blue Robin Song)
21
4
f
(Nilgiri Blue Robin Song)


25
𝅗𝅥. = ♩ (♩ = 66.6)
p
p
mp
p
27


29
détaché
("The water mafia")
mp
p
("The water mafia")
31

33

mf

détaché

mf

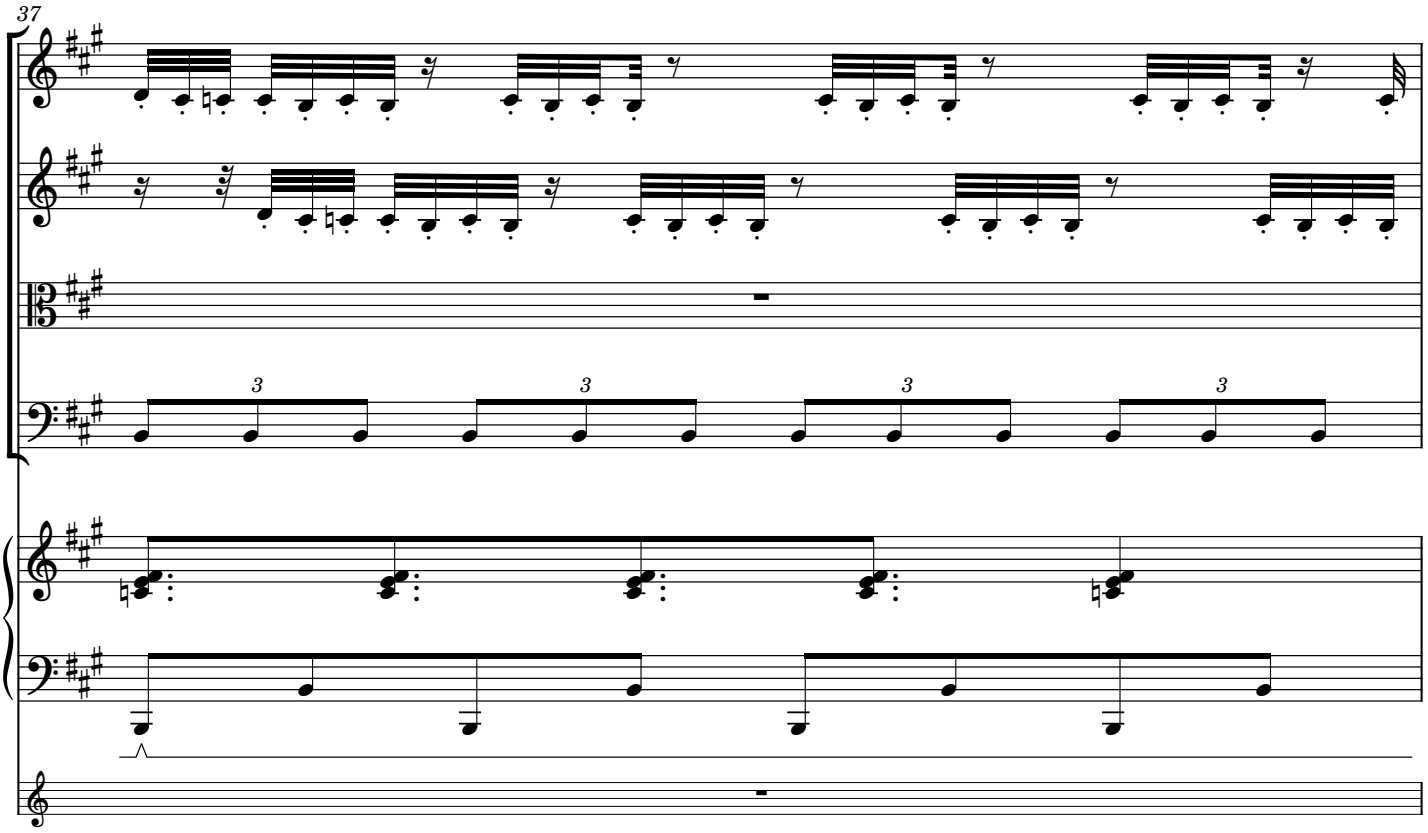
3 3 3 3 3 3 3 3

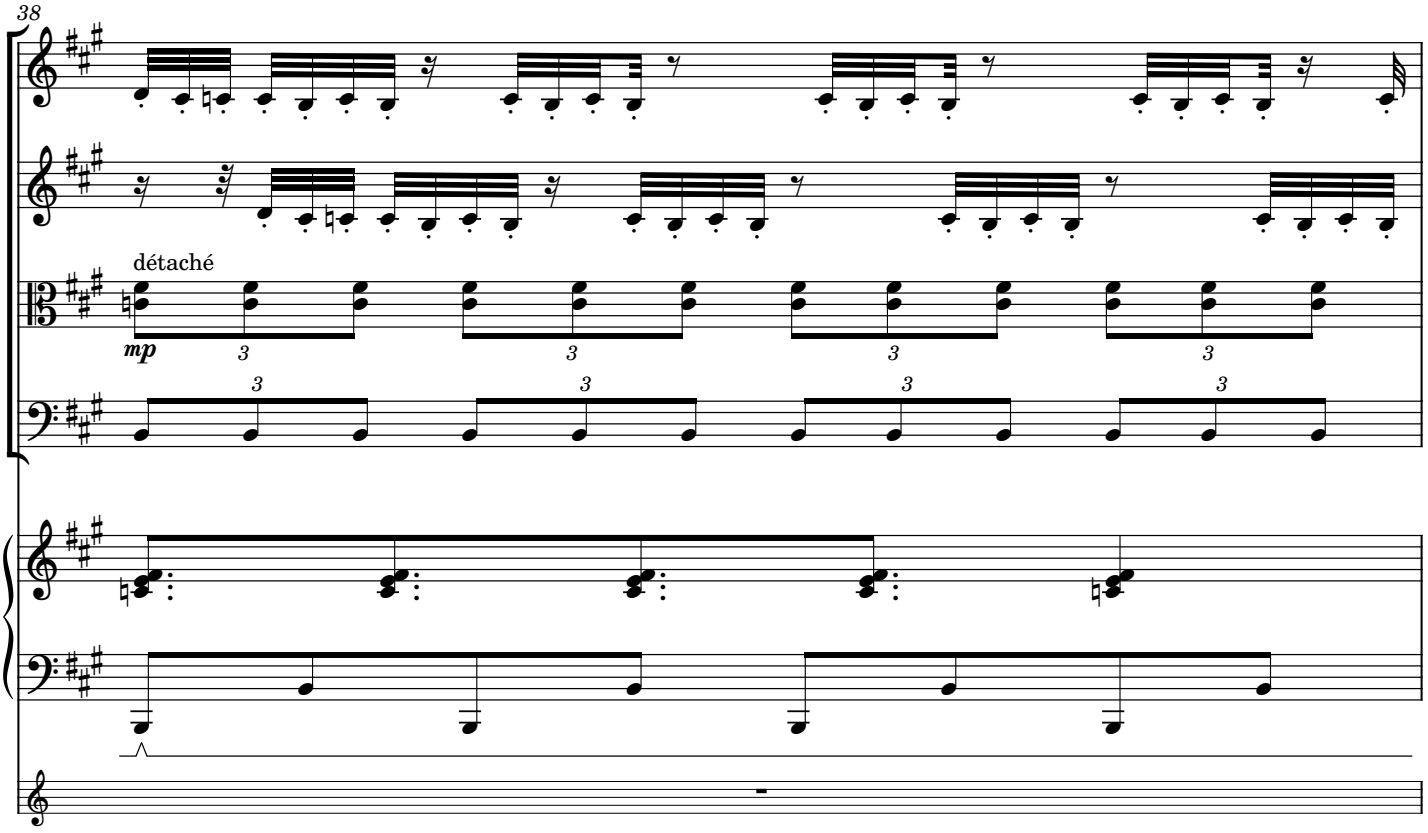
3 3 3 3 3 3 3 3
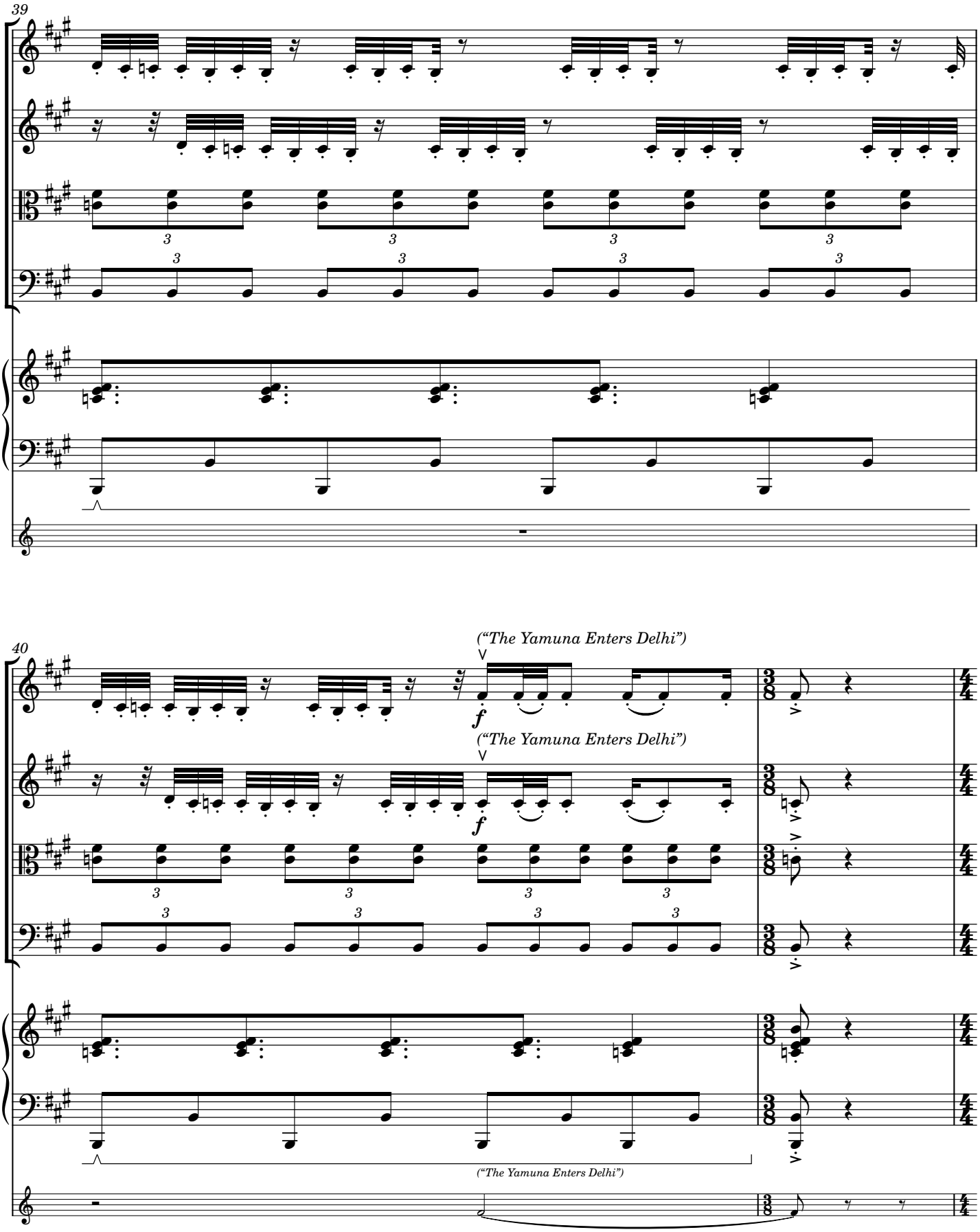
35
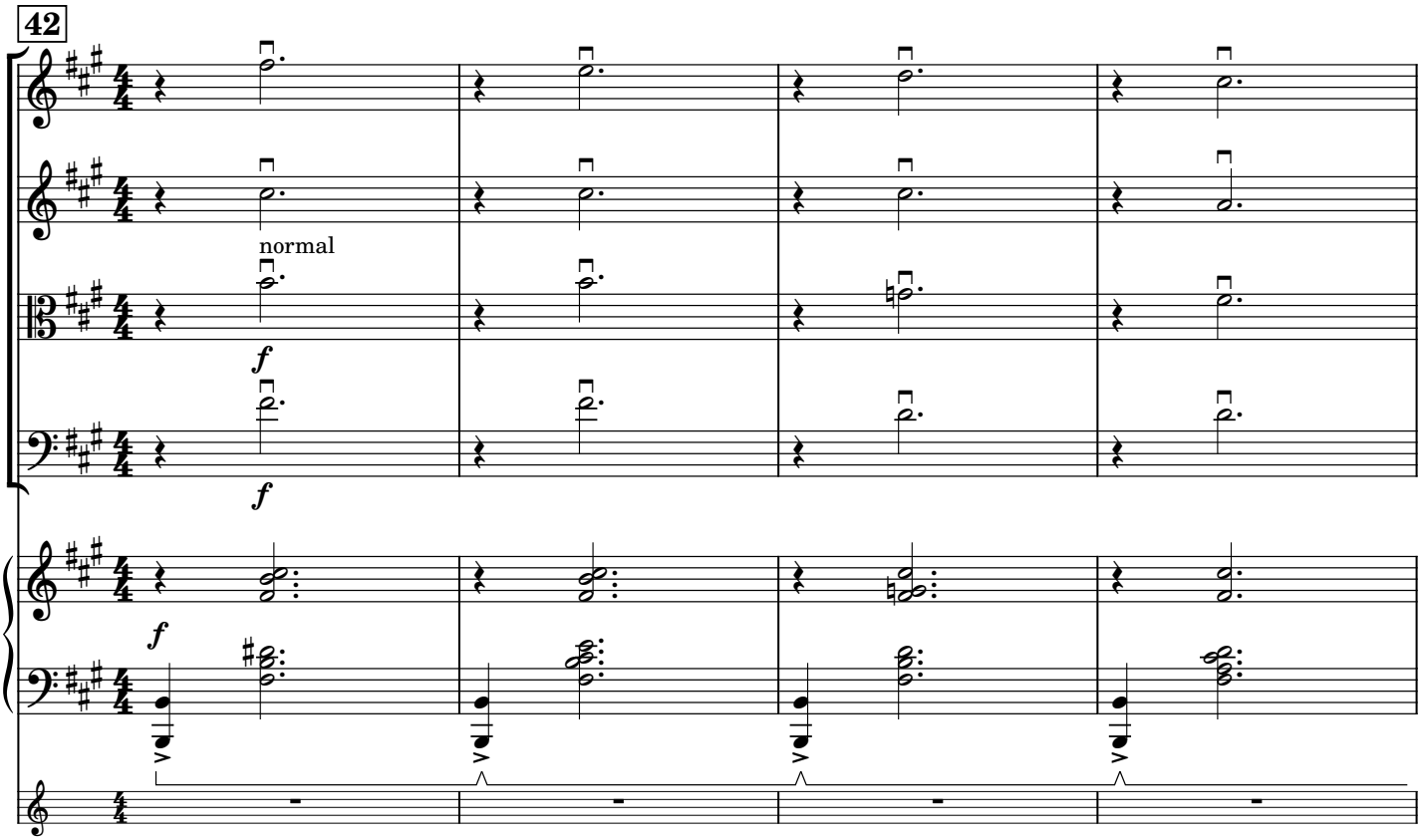
3 3 3 3 3 3 3 3

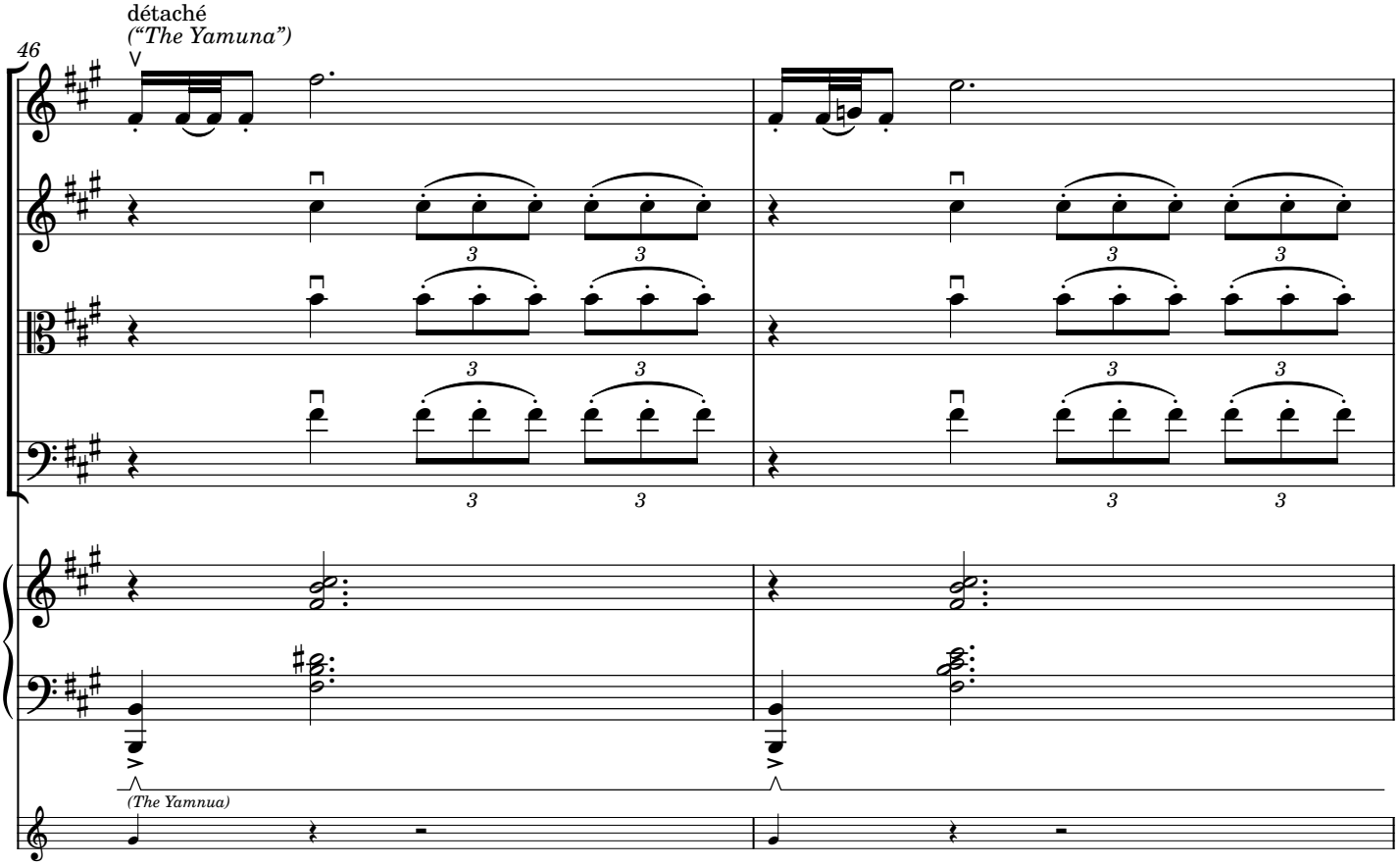
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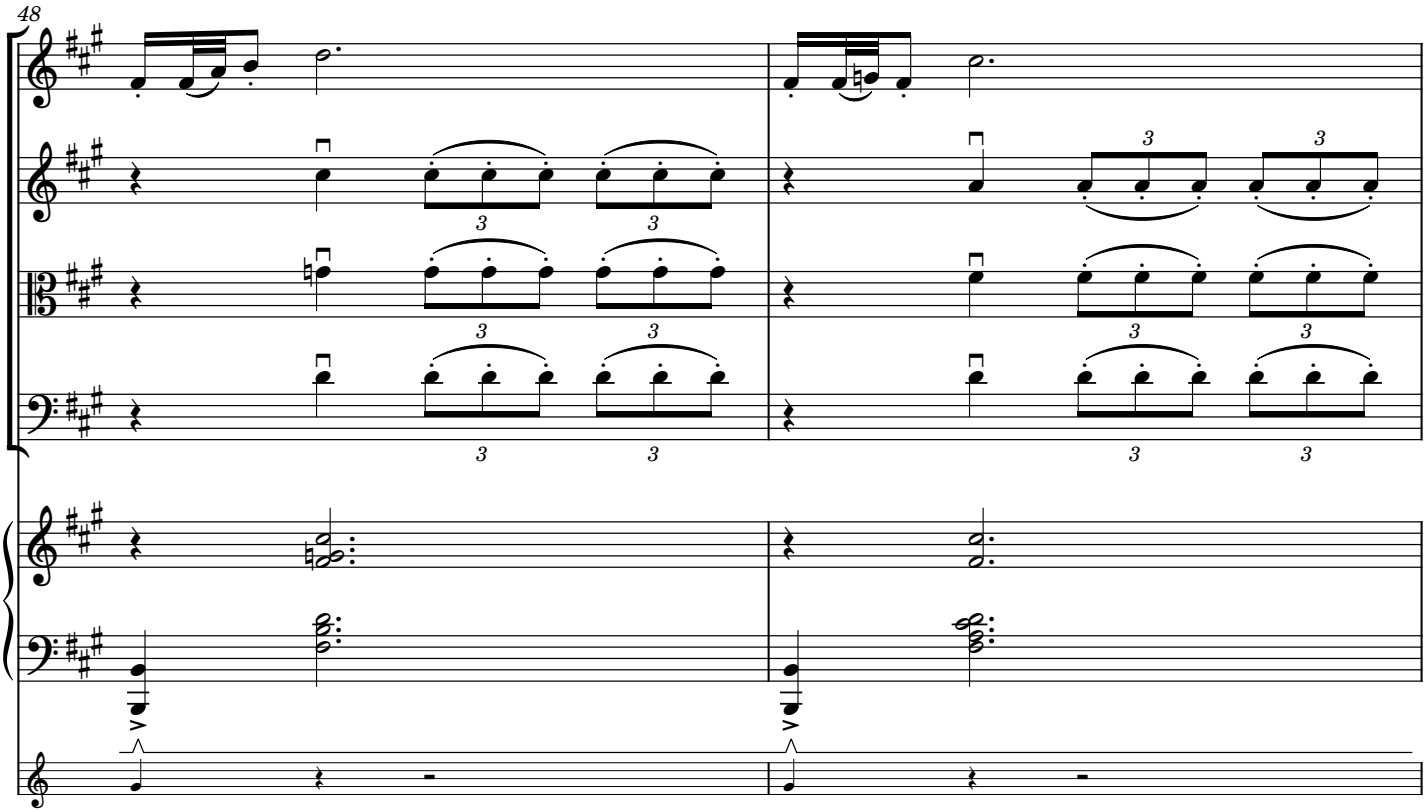

37
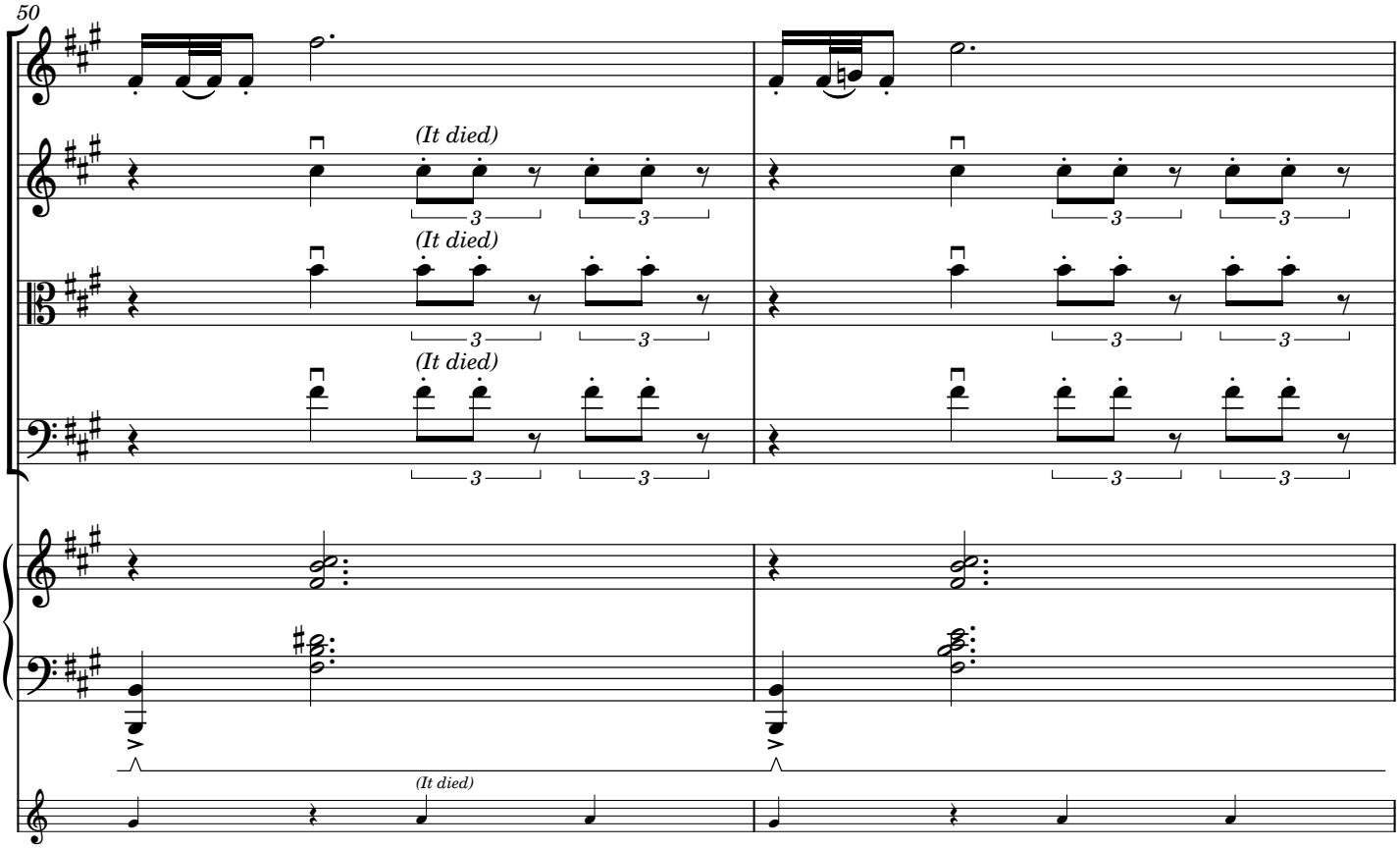

38
détaché
mp

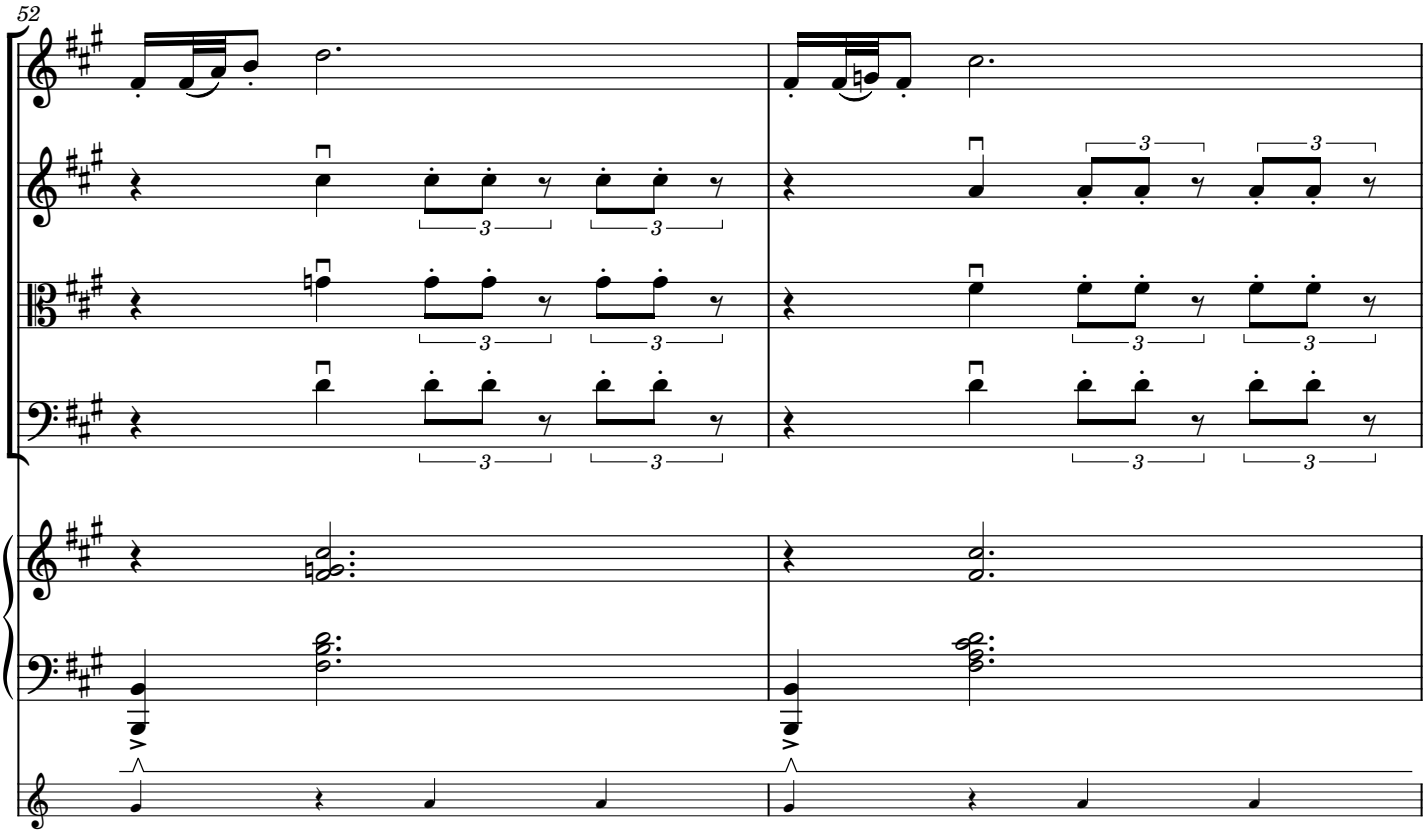

39
40
("The Yamuna Enters Delhi")
("The Yamuna Enters Delhi")
("The Yamuna Enters Delhi")
("The Yamuna Enters Delhi")
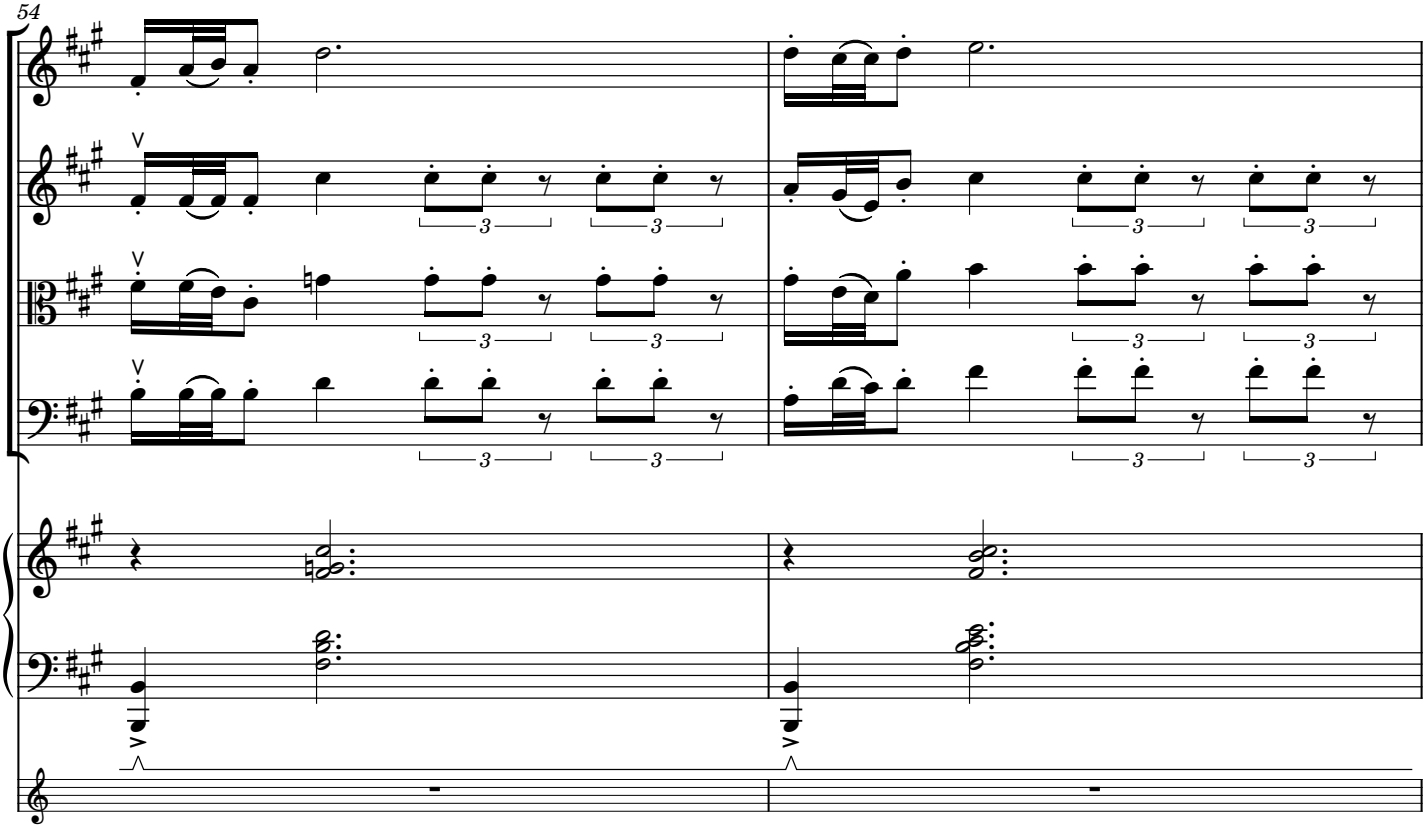

42
normal
f
f
f
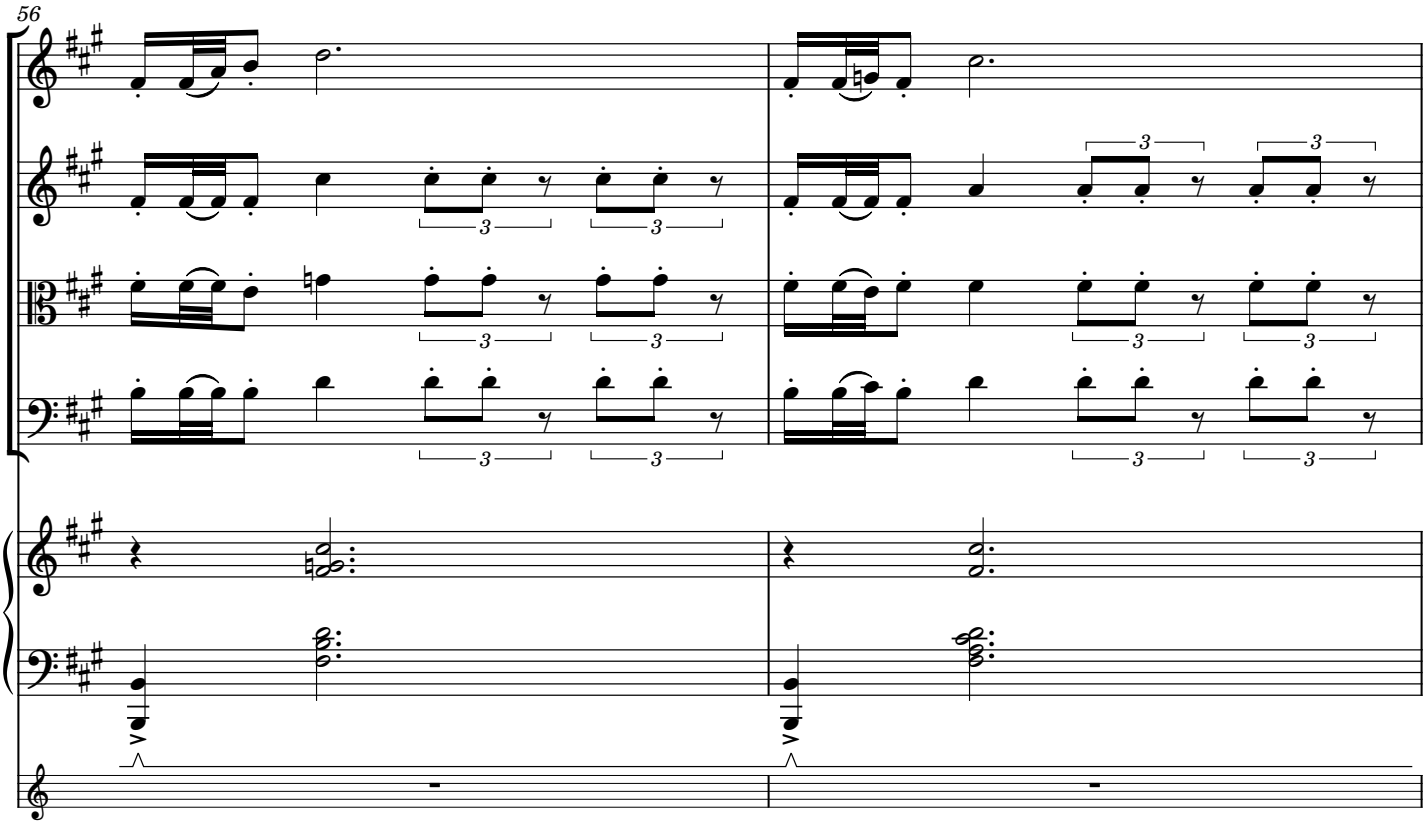

46
détaché
("The Yamuna")
3
(The Yamnua)
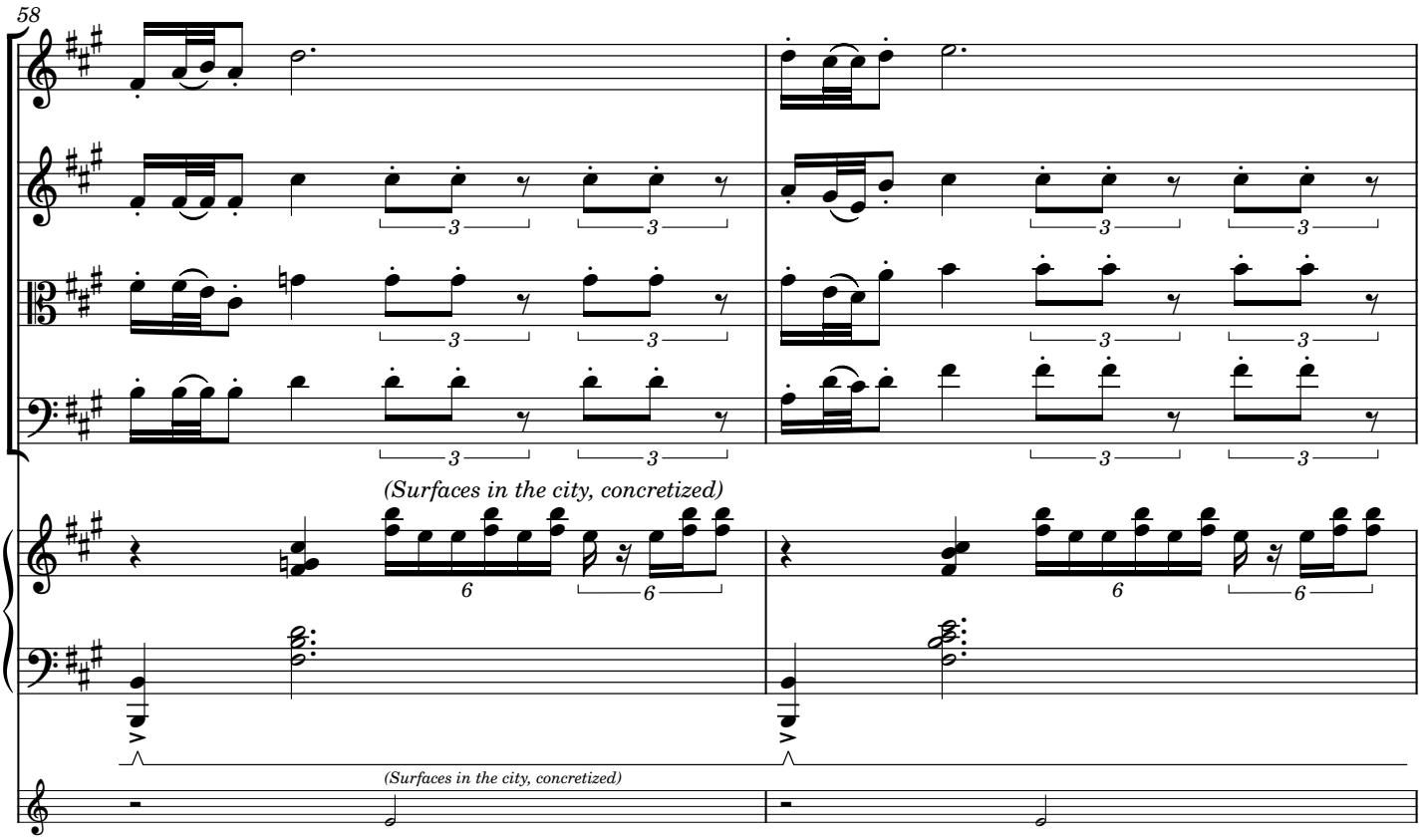

48
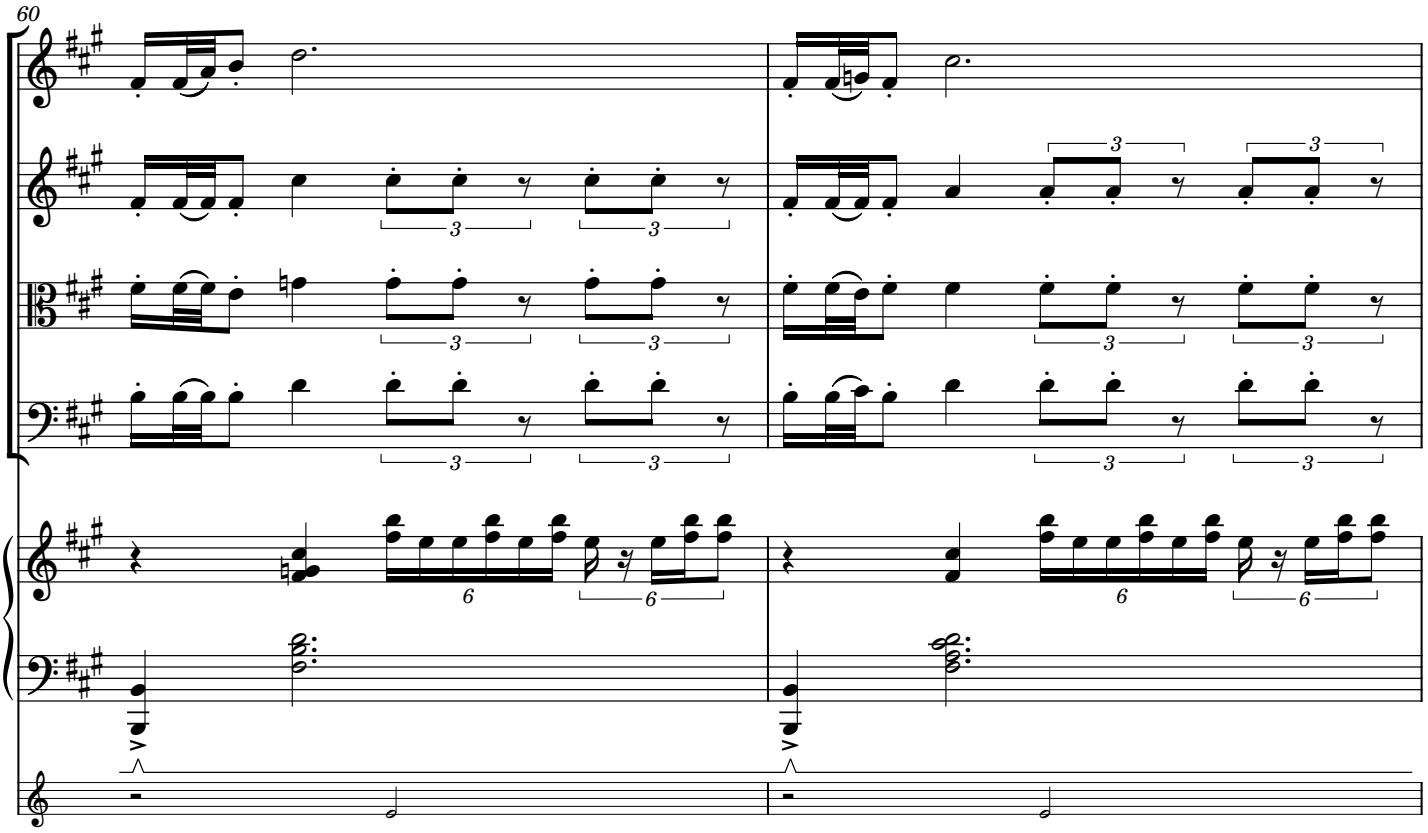

50
(It died)
(It died)
(It died)
(It died)
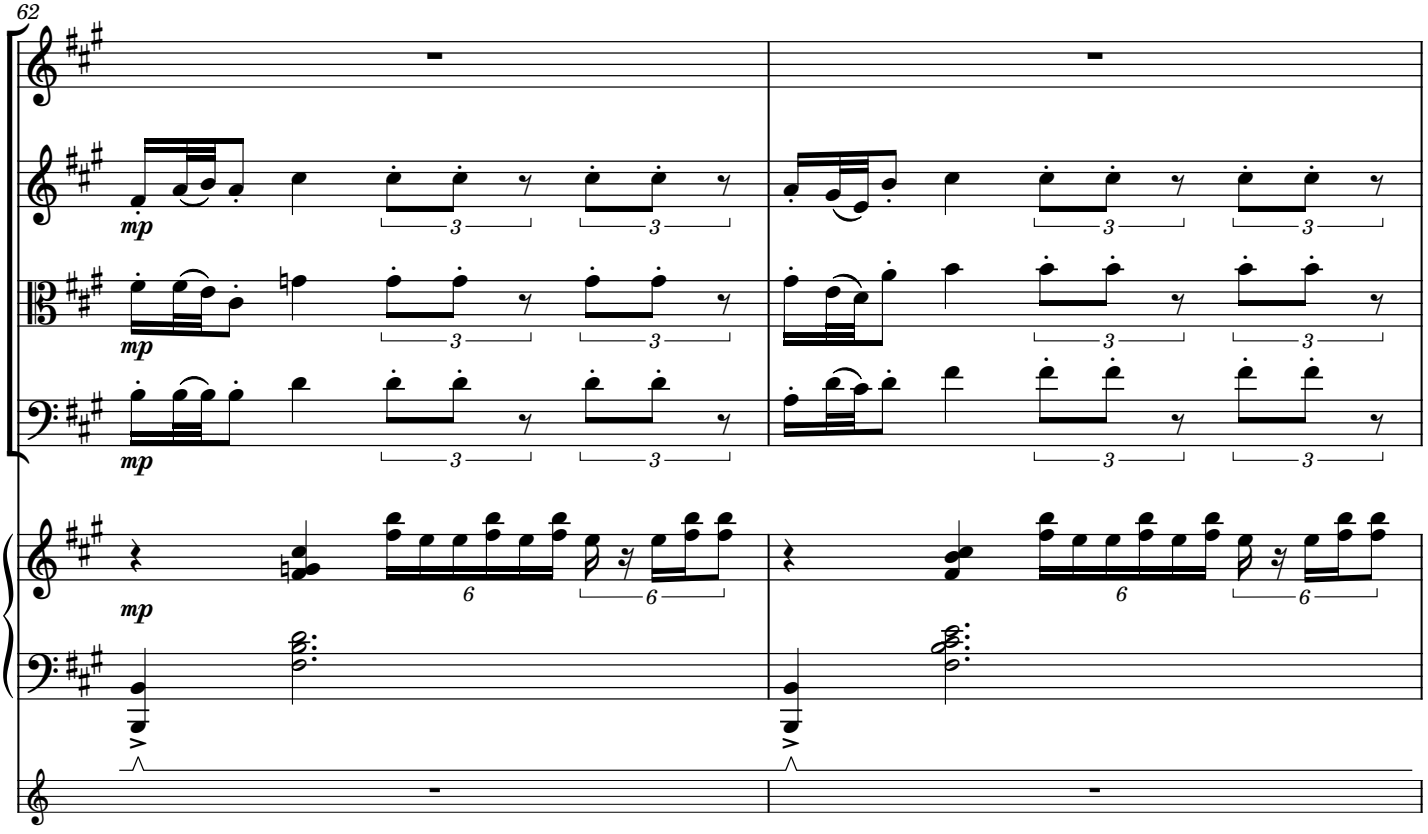

52
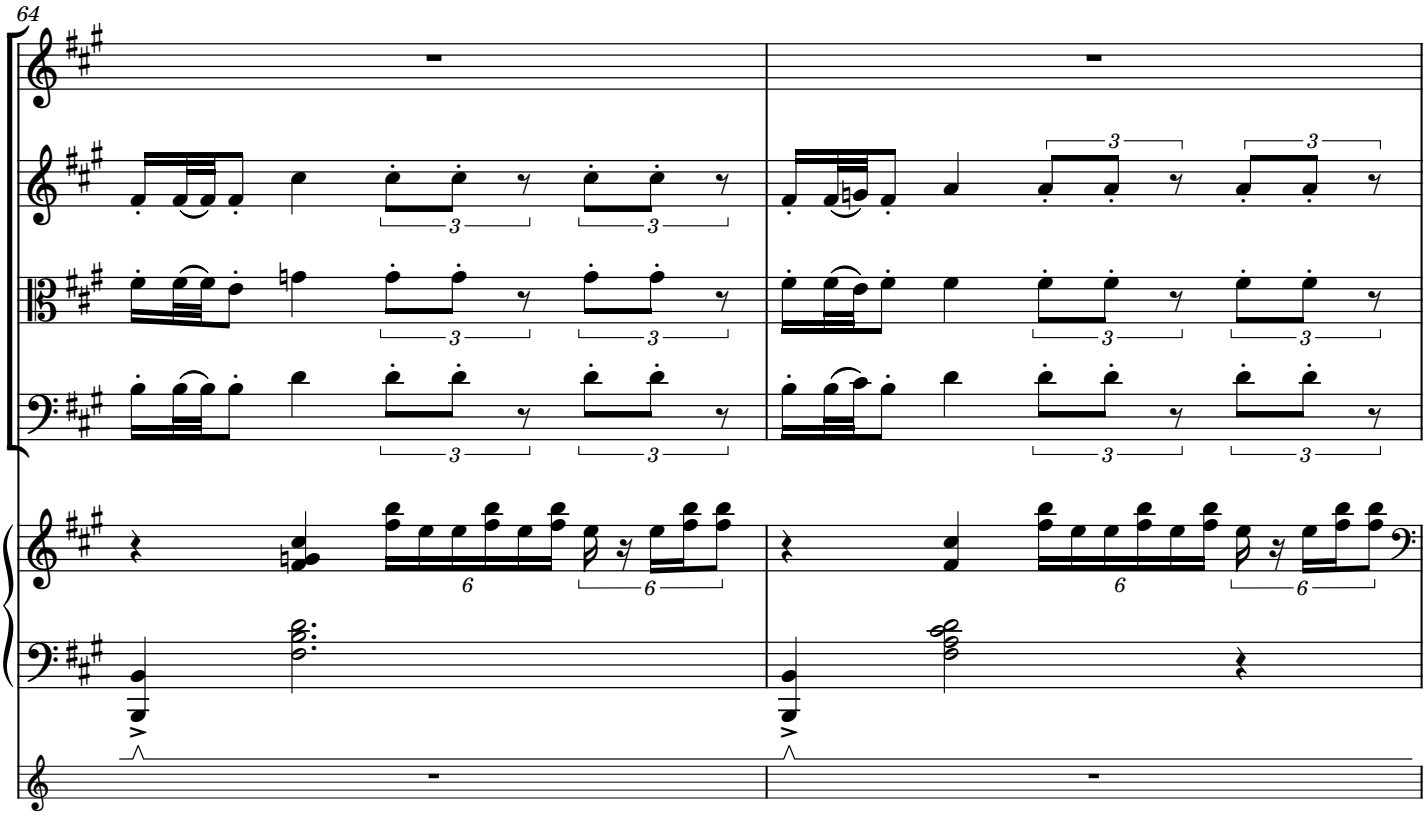

54
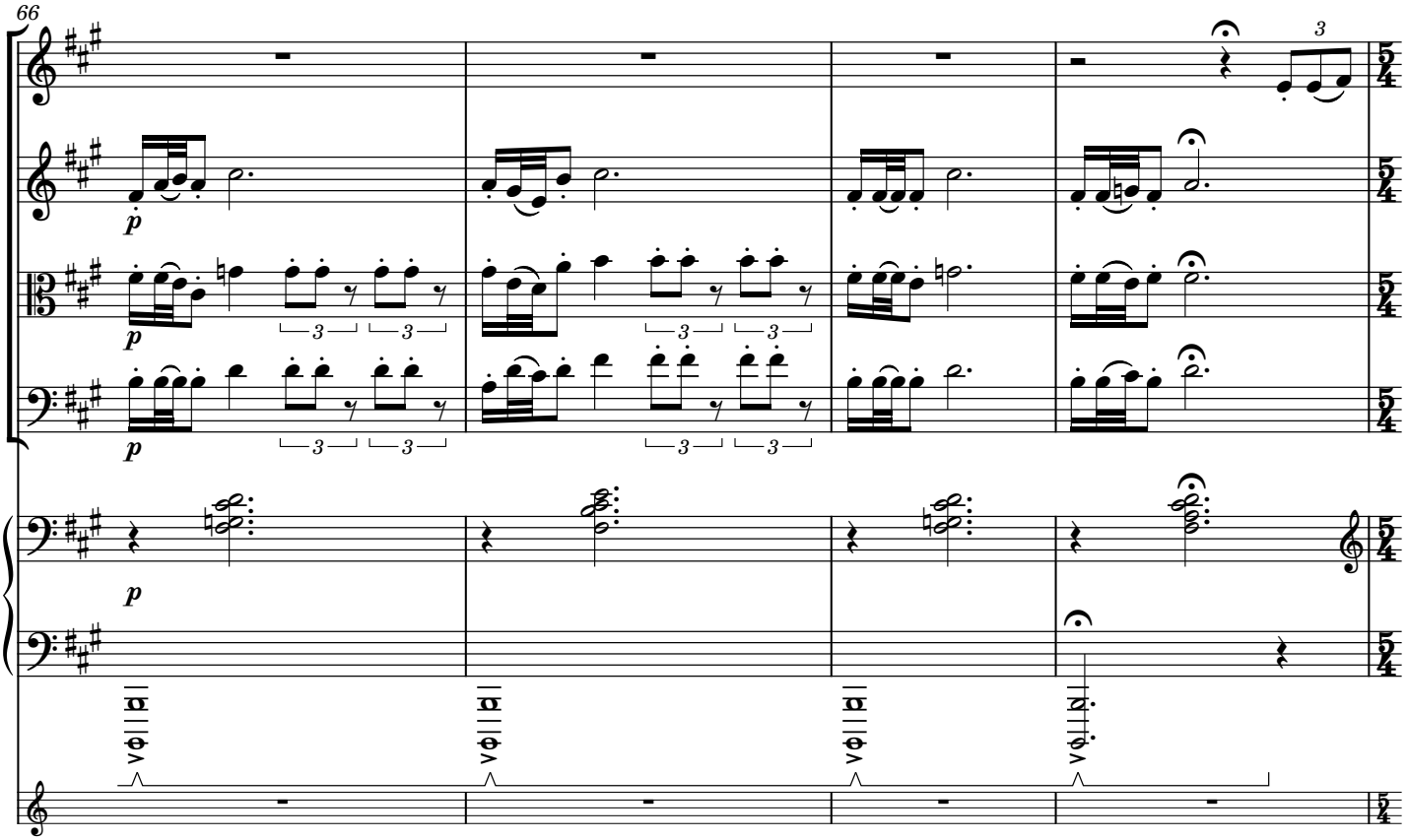

56
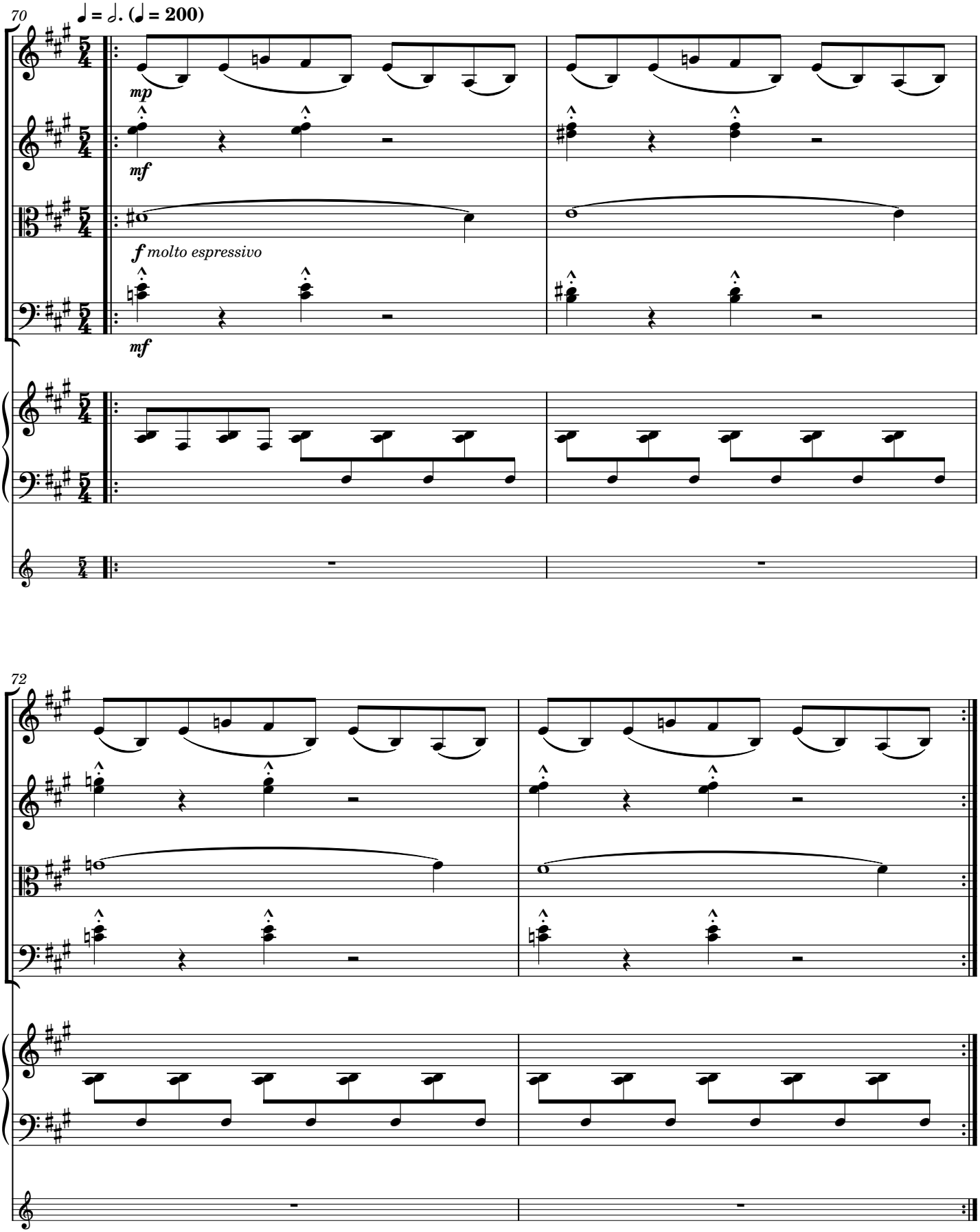

58
(Surfaces in the city, concretized)
(Surfaces in the city, concretized)


60

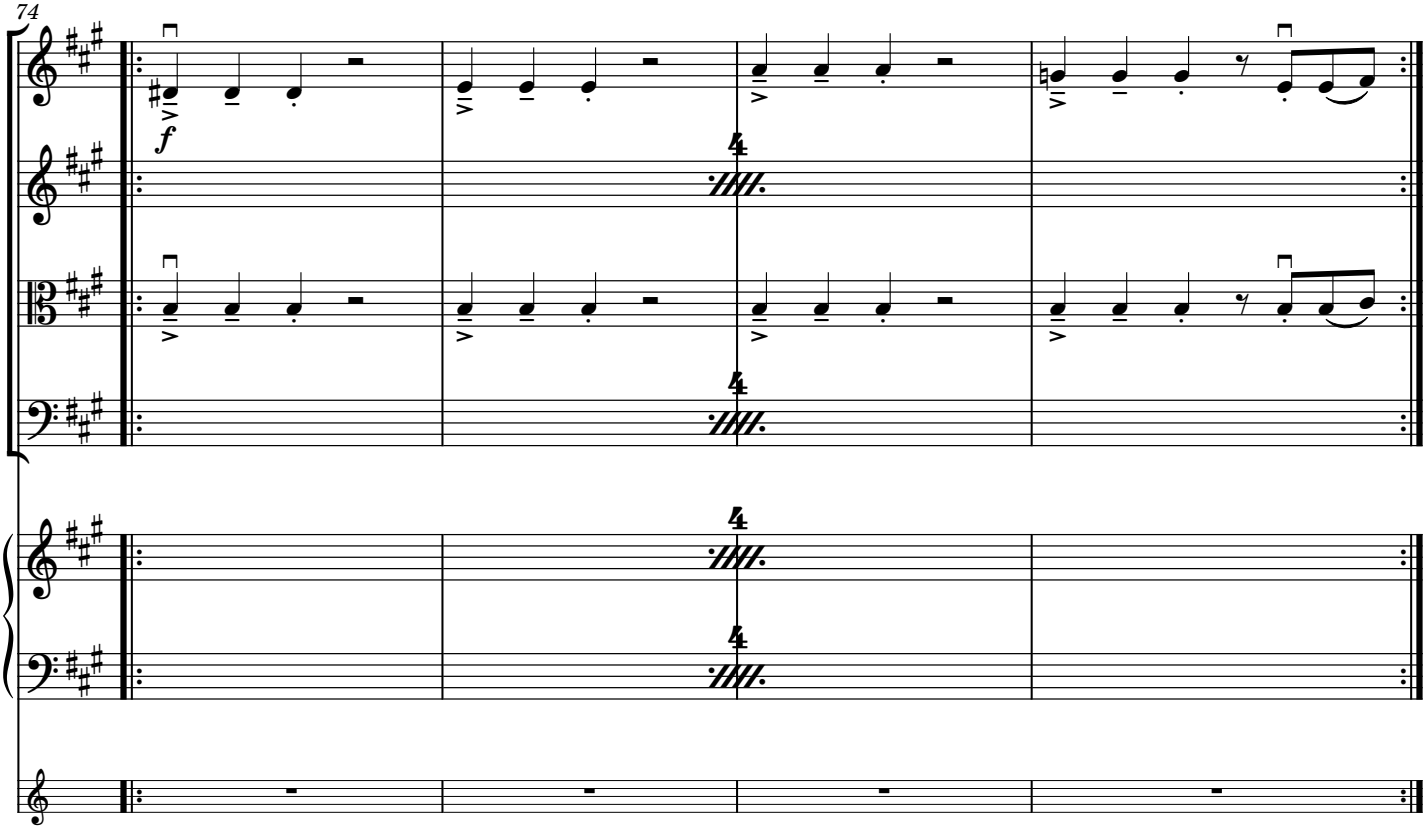

62
mp
mp
mp


64


66


70
♩ = 𝅗𝅥. (♩ = 200)
mp
mf
f molto espressivo
mf
72

74



78

